DAILY ROUTINE: C1 LEVEL

Learning how to talk about your daily routine is typically one of the first things you learn when you begin learning English. However, in this lesson, I'm going to walk you through my daily routine using C1-level grammar and vocabulary. I will then go through some of these advanced grammar topics and give you the definitions and example sentences of loads of C1-level vocabulary. I've also included a quiz at the end to wrap it all up!

My Routine: Part 1

Upon waking up to the melodious chimes of my alarm clock, I embark on my well-established morning routine that I've perfected over the years. First and foremost, I indulge in a brief meditation session, allowing me to clear my mind and start the day with a sense of calm. In addition to my mental exercise, I dive into a challenging 30-minute workout session, but I guess it isn't so much challenging as it is invigorating. After freshening up, I pamper myself with my nourishing skincare regimen, ensuring a well-hydrated and glowing complexion.

GRAMMAR BREAKDOWN

Let's look at this first paragraph a bit deeper. We can start by looking at these three clauses:

- *Upon waking up to the melodious chimes of my alarm clock*
- *allowing me to clear my mind and start the day with a sense of calm*
- *ensuring a well-hydrated and glowing complexion*

They are known as ***non-finite clauses***. This is a topic we cover in-depth in my C1 programme, but here is a quick explanation of non-finite clauses.

Non-finite clauses

A non-finite clause is a type of clause that **doesn't have a subject and a finite verb** (a verb with tense and agreement). In other words, it's an incomplete sentence that can't stand alone as a complete thought. Non-finite clauses use

the **base form** (infinitive) or the **-ing form** (present participle) without specific subject information.

Advanced Comparative Structures

Now, let's take a minute to look at this structure:

- *it isn't so much challenging as it is invigorating...*

Using **not so much + adjective + as + adjective** is an advanced comparative structure we use to compare two related qualities.

Compound Adjectives

Okay, let me address one more grammar concept before we move on to the rest of my routine: compound adjectives, like—

- ***well-established***
- ***30-minute***
- ***well-hydrated***

Compound adjectives are adjectives that are formed by combining two or more words to create a single descriptive term. These adjectives are commonly used to **convey complex or specific qualities** that may not be easily expressed with a single word.

I used several hyphenated compound adjectives in this first paragraph. We use the hyphens to clarify that the words are meant to be taken together as a single descriptive unit. There are other forms of compound adjectives that I cover in my C1 programme.

VOCABULARY

melodious /məˈləʊdiəs/ - having a pleasant and harmonious sound
Whitney Houston's melodious voice captivated the audience.

to embark /ɪmˈbɑːk/ - to begin or start a journey or other task, often with a sense of enthusiasm
They decided to embark on a round-the-world trip to explore different cultures.

first and foremost - primarily or above all; the most important thing to consider
First and foremost, the health and safety of our passengers is our top priority.

to indulge /ɪnˈdʌldʒ/ - to allow oneself to enjoy or partake in something pleasurable
I decided to indulge in a rich chocolate cake on my birthday.

to dive into - to enthusiastically start something like an activity or project
He couldn't wait to dive into the new novel he had just bought.

invigorating /ɪnˈvɪgəreɪtɪŋ/ - energising or refreshing; a feeling of renewed energy
The only way she can fully wake up is by taking an invigorating morning jog in the crisp air.

to freshen up - to clean or revitalise oneself by washing or tidying up, often in relation to personal appearance
After the long flight, he took a quick shower to freshen up before his big meeting.

to pamper /ˈpæmpə/ - to treat someone or oneself with special care, attention and indulgence
As it was her birthday, Emma decided to pamper herself with a relaxing spa day.

nourishing /ˈnʌrɪʃɪŋ/ - providing essential nutrients and promoting health and well-being
Mum's famous hearty vegetable soup was not only delicious but also nourishing.

regimen /ˈredʒɪmən/ - a structured and planned routine or set of activities
Samuel followed a strict exercise regimen to stay fit and healthy.

complexion /kəmˈplekʃn/ - the natural colour, texture and appearance of the skin on a person's face
What moisturiser do you use to maintain such a smooth complexion?

My Routine: Part 2

No sooner have I got dressed in my most casual yet professional attire than I am wolfing down a hearty breakfast to fuel my day ahead. With a steaming cup of herbal tea in hand, I scan the morning headlines to stay informed on the happenings of the world. Meanwhile, as I commute to work, I immerse myself in an audiobook, relishing the well-written prose and captivating storytelling. Thus, I arrive at work ready to tackle the day ahead of me.

GRAMMAR BREAKDOWN

Negative Inversion

In the first sentence, "**No sooner have I got dressed in my most casual yet professional attire than I am wolfing down a hearty breakfast to fuel my day ahead,**" the construction "*No sooner have I got dressed*" is an example of **negative inversion**.

Negative inversion is a grammatical structure where the usual word order of a sentence is inverted or changed when a negative adverbial expression is used at the beginning of the sentence. Instead of the regular word order **subject-verb**, we use the inverted order **adverb-verb-subject**.

The construction is important because it adds emphasis. I'm not just saying, "I have got dressed," but I'm highlighting the immediacy of the action by using "no sooner."

This construction often indicates that one action happens immediately after another, almost without any delay. Using negative inversion helps to add a little flair to the story instead of sticking to the same subject-verb type construction — but it should be used sparingly.

Signposts

The final two sentences featured **signposts**, words like '**meanwhile**' and '**thus**'.

Using signposting language is like giving your writing a GPS – it helps steer your audience smoothly along and keeps your thoughts organised. These little words and phrases act as the glue that holds your writing together.

Think of it this way: without these signposting cues, your writing could get all jumbled up and end up sounding like a bunch of random thoughts.

COMPREHENSION CHECK!

Can you identify the signposting language in our first paragraph?

Upon waking up to the melodious chimes of my alarm clock, I embark on my well-established morning routine that I've perfected over the years. First and foremost, I indulge in a brief meditation session, allowing me to clear my mind and start the day with a sense of calm. In addition to my mental exercise, I dive into a challenging 30-minute workout session, but I guess it isn't so much challenging as it is invigorating. After freshening up, I pamper myself with my nourishing skincare regimen, ensuring a well-hydrated and glowing complexion.

Here is the signposting language used in this paragraph:

- ***First and foremost***
- ***in addition to***
- ***after***

If that gave you a bit of trouble, don't worry! You will learn all about signposting in my C1 programme.

VOCABULARY

attire /əˈtaɪə/ - clothing; garments or outfits worn by a person
The description for the event said 'casual cocktail attire', but what does that mean?

to wolf down - to eat something quickly
He was so hungry that he wolfed down his burger in a matter of seconds.

to scan /skæn/ - to examine or look over something quickly and systematically, often to find specific information or details
Brenda scanned the document quickly to see if the information would jump out at her.

to commute /kəˈmjuːt/ - to travel regularly between one's home and workplace
It gets a bit tiring having to commute by train to the city every day.

to immerse /ɪˈmɜːs/ - to deeply involve or engage oneself in an activity, subject or experience
After her break-up, she chose to immerse herself in meditation and self-care.

to relish /ˈrelɪʃ/ - to take great pleasure in or appreciate
We relished the opportunity to travel and explore new cultures.

prose /prəʊz/ - written or spoken language in its ordinary form, without the rhythmic and metrical structure of poetry
The novel is written in beautiful prose that captivates the reader.

to tackle /ˈtækl/ - to confront or deal with in a determined manner
With a cup of coffee in hand, she was ready to tackle the mountain of paperwork on her desk.

My Routine: Part 3

Upon arriving at the office, I buckle down and get on with my work, meticulously completing my tasks in the most efficient way possible. It is knowing that I am contributing in a meaningful way that I thrive on, and I actively seek opportunities to enhance my skill set. Throughout the day, I engage in productive dialogues with colleagues, synergising ideas and learning from their unique perspectives.

GRAMMAR BREAKDOWN

Post-modified Adjectives

First, we have the clause "***meticulously completing my tasks in the most efficient way possible***", which utilises a **post-modified superlative adjective**.

A post-modified superlative adjective is **placed after the noun**. It modifies and adds emphasis or specific information about the noun. This construction is **used to highlight the extreme quality** of the noun in comparison to others of its kind.

Cleft Sentences

The structure of the second sentence was a bit of an odd one: ***It is knowing that I am contributing in a meaningful way that I thrive on, and I actively seek opportunities to enhance my skill set.***

We call this a **cleft sentence**, a grammatical construction **used to emphasise a particular element in a sentence by dividing it into two clauses**. The purpose of a cleft sentence is to bring attention to a specific part of the sentence, often by reorganising the structure to highlight that element.

In this case, I wanted to highlight 'knowing that I am contributing in a meaningful way', so I was able to restructure my sentence to make sure that this portion of the sentence was the main focus.

VOCABULARY

to buckle down - to apply oneself diligently and with determination to a task
With exams approaching, Ben decided it was time to buckle down and study.

to get on with something - to start or continue with a task or activity, often without unnecessary delay
Can we get on with the meeting, or are we going to wait for Amir?

meticulously /məˈtɪkjʊləsli/ - in a very careful and precise manner, paying great attention to details
He meticulously arranged the flowers on each table.

to thrive on - to succeed or find enjoyment and motivation in a particular situation, challenge or environment
Greg truly thrives on the fast-paced nature of his job.

to engage /ɪnˈgeɪdʒ/ - to become involved, participate or interact with something or someone actively
He's been engaged in a riveting game of poker for the past three hours.

dialogue /ˈdaɪəlɒg/ - a conversation or discussion between two or more people
After months of dialogues with the higher-ups, we are all getting pay rises!

to synergise /ˈsɪnədʒaɪz/ - to combine different elements or efforts to create a mutually beneficial outcome
The marketing team spent months figuring out how to synergise their skills to produce outstanding results.

My Routine: Part 4

As the day draws to a close, I reflect on my achievements, striving to be the best version of myself both personally and professionally. All I hope is that I outdo my previous accomplishments each day as I embrace life with unwavering determination. By adopting this disciplined and purposeful routine, I feel confident that I can continue on a path of self-improvement and well-being.

GRAMMAR BREAKDOWN

Let's look at our first sentence—
As the day draws to a close, I reflect on my achievements, striving to be the best version of myself both personally and professionally.

We have a few different things going on. First, we have '*as the day draws to a close*', which is a **subordinate clause**, but you should already be familiar with those. These are **clauses that can't stand on their own as individual sentences.** They have to be attached to a main or independent clause.

But, we also have a participle clause: ***striving to be the best version of myself both personally and professionally.***

A **participle clause** is **a type of non-finite clause**. The example consists of a present participle — striving.

We also have a participle clause in our last sentence: ***By adopting this disciplined and purposeful routine...***

This participle clause also functions as an adverbial phrase because I used the preposition 'by', explaining how the action in the main clause is achieved.

Finally, we saw another common construction of a cleft sentence: ***All I hope is that I outdo my previous accomplishments each day as I embrace life with unwavering determination.***

The structure **what/all + clause + be + clause** is quite commonly used, so it's a good one to have in your back pocket.

VOCABULARY

to draw to a close - to come to the end of an event, period or activity
As the sun set, the day began to draw to a close, and everyone started heading home.

to reflect /rɪˈflekt/ - to think deeply about something
We took some time to reflect on what happened before making a decision.

achievement /əˈtʃiːvmənt/ - an accomplishment or success gained through effort or hard work
His academic and professional achievements are truly remarkable.

the best version of oneself - striving to reach one's highest potential
Through dedication and self-improvement, Glenda aspired to be the best version of herself.

accomplishment /əˈkʌmplɪʃmənt/ - the successful completion of a task, project or goal
His numerous accomplishments in the field of science were recognised with prestigious awards.

to embrace /ɪmˈbreɪs/ - to accept something with enthusiasm and openness
They decided to embrace the new challenges at work and make the most of the situation.

unwavering /ʌnˈweɪvərɪŋ/ - steady, resolute and not faltering
Your unwavering dedication to your morals is truly commendable and deserving of respect.

determination /dɪˌtɜːmɪˈneɪʃən/ - the quality of being firm and committed to achieving goals, often in the face of challenges or obstacles
Her determination to succeed drove her to overcome every obstacle in her path.

to adopt /əˈdɒpt/ - to take up, accept or embrace a practice, belief or approach, often incorporating it into one's own life or routine
My aunt has decided to adopt a healthier lifestyle by exercising regularly and eating nutritious foods.

QUIZ!

Choose the correct phrases from the Word Bank to complete the conversation.

Johan, a dedicated baker, starts each day with an (1) _____ dedication to creating delicious treats. First and foremost, he puts on his baking (2) _____: a white coat that reflects his professionalism. With a cup of coffee in hand, he (3) _____ into the day's tasks, (4) _____ himself in the joy of crafting exquisite pastries. Johan (5) _____ on the (6) _____ aromas that fill his bakery as the ovens warm up.

He (7) _____ measures ingredients, embracing each step of the baking process with care. Nourishing creations like hearty bread and muffins are his specialities, providing customers with a taste of comfort and health. As the morning draws to a close, Johan takes a moment to reflect on his (8) _____ and to relish the satisfaction of a well-baked batch.

After lunch, he (9) _____ on experimenting with new recipes, taking the opportunity to indulge his creativity. With his apron dusted with flour, he (10) _____ the challenge of crafting delicate pastries. Later, he takes a short break to pamper himself with a warm cup of tea and a moment of peace.

As the sun sets, Johan embraces the satisfaction of a productive day. He believes in embracing the journey and thoroughly enjoying the process. With his bakery humming along, Johan is ready to take on another day of creating delectable delights.

Word Bank

a. accomplishments
b. meticulously
c. invigorating
d. unwavering
e. attire
f. thrives
g. dives
h. immersing
i. tackles
j. embarks

The End!

1) d 2) e 3) g 4) h 5) f 6) c 7) b 8) a 9) j 10) i